meaning of the word “history” is investigation, and the Hindus never appear to have cared to investigate.’[6]

That remarkable Italian philosopher Roberto Calasso has more recently stated much the same thing in highlighting the differences between the classical Western mode of thinking and the Vedic thought that continues to underpin much of Hindu society to this day:

> For a Westerner trained in philology, it is hard to think of anything more frustrating than Indian history. Quicksand in every direction. Dates and figures never certain. Here the centuries move back and forth as months do elsewhere … There is no point in looking for help from historical events, since there is no trace of them. Only texts remain: the *Veda*, the Knowledge, consisting of hymns, invocations, incantations in verse, of ritual formulas and prescriptions in prose … The Arya (‘the nobles’, as Vedic men called themselves) ignored history with a disdain unequalled in the annals of any other great civilisation.[7]

I can vividly recall my first encounter with this Vedic hangover. I had long wanted to visit the traditional sources of the Ganges at Badrinath and Gangotri in the Garhwal Himal, and that opportunity became available to me in 1979, when the Indian Government relaxed some of its prohibitions against foreigners approaching its border with Tibet. Because photographer Richard Cooke and I were the first foreigners to be allowed in we were treated with justifiable suspicion when we arrived at the starting point of our trek, which was the check-post at Uttarkashi. Here we were joined by a well-spoken official who announced that he would be coming with us, ‘purely as a fellow-traveller, you understand’.

This would have been fine had it not been for the determination of this gentleman to lecture us on the glories